when the Hindi film industry is going through a phase of much introspection as action entertainers from the South and tentpole Hollywood titles rule the box office. "No one knows what to do," says Kareena. The pandemic, she feels, has changed the audience's mindsets and preferences. "No actors are superstars now. That concept is diminishing," she says. "It's the era of actors, of content. It's an exciting time for actors to learn and do different things."

Kareena, for her part, is doing exactly that. She will soon make her streaming debut with an adaptation of Keigo Higashino's Japanese mystery-thriller novel, *The Devotion of Suspect X*, a Netflix original directed by Sujoy Ghosh, also starring Jaideep Ahlawat and Vijay Varma. Her next project sees her collaborate with *Shahid* (2020) and *Scam 1992* (2020) director Hansal Mehta. Another film with *Veere Di Wedding* (2018) producer Rhea Kapoor is also in the pipeline.

On June 30, the actress completed 22 years in the industry. She says she intends to clock in at least another 22 years. The trick to staying relevant, she feels, lies in being true to oneself and adapting with the changing times. "I've not tried to be somebody else," she says. "I'm passionate about food. I want to do good work. I'm a fiercely private person who values my time with family and friends. I don't take anything for granted." As Kareena Kapoor Khan again digs in her heels, it seems clear that this time she isn't going to doll up to make an impression. ■

–Suhani SIngh

OTT

Casting New Light

With *Maharani*'s second season about to release, actress Huma Qureshi says the show has given her fresh courage

Huma Qureshi had little idea that a Zoom narration during the Covid-19 pandemic in early 2020 would lead to one of the most compelling roles of her career. The role required the Delhi girl to play a mother of three kids from a village in Bihar—"unglamorous", as she puts it. "One didn't know which way it would go," recalls Qureshi. "It could go so wrong, but if it goes right..." It did. In *Maharani* (2021–), Qureshi, 36, plays Rani Bharti, a woman who is forced to fill in for her injured politician husband and made chief minister. The part has ended up being a "gamechanger" for Qureshi's career. "I thank Subhash Kapoor [creator] daily for pushing me to submit to it," she says. "*Maharani* has unlocked a part of me that is unafraid and I want to explore that."

Today, Qureshi is busier than ever. Her present slate only proves how spoilt for choice she has been of late. Qureshi turns producer and stars alongside Sonakshi Sinha in *Double XL*, a film that will highlight the body-shaming that women suffer. In the upcoming Netflix dark comedy *Monica O My Darling*, she has acted in her "favourite scene ever" with Rajkummar Rao. In her first biopic, Qureshi will be seen playing popular cook and author Tarla Dalal. She will also feature in a thriller, *Pooja Meri Jaan*. Qureshi says, "I am just having fun, being more myself and playing characters that resonate with me."

It wasn't always like that. After having done some theatre in the capital, when she started her cinematic journey, Qureshi says she was "following the herd": "I was trying to do the conventional because that's what works and that's what everyone was doing." The new Qureshi, however, has no qualms in playing a mother or using prosthetics that push her front teeth out. "It is sad that we tell women that as long as you are unattached, you are of value. Today, we have actresses who are getting married and having babies. A few years back, people would hide because it wasn't seen as being desirable enough."

Unlike Amazon Prime political drama *Tandav* (2021–), which faced legal trouble in the aftermath of its release, *Maharani*, a show Qureshi calls "political fantasy fiction", has largely avoided controversy. As she reprises her character for a new season (releasing on SonyLIV on August 25), Qureshi says the show has resonated because it adheres to the underdog template. "Ultimately, what Rani Bharti represents is any common man's dream and desire—to have a better society, regardless of political ideology. It is inconceivable to have that kind of power, and for her to still be a champion."

–Suhani Singh

Playing the accidental and reluctant chief minister of Bihar has been a 'gamechanger' for **HUMA QURESHI**



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